State Discussion Forum

The objective of this committee is simple, finding out the best way in which a state could function.

Now there are a lot of interesting things this committee will familiarize you with,

Firstly as you're already aware you a representatives are not bound by any sort of portfolios or policies, this is a simple platform in which you as individuals would put forward points of view which would be your own, there are a number of broad stances you can take all of which would be mentioned within this document.

Second, not only do you decide what your stance and path of discussion individually you also decide how debate in the committee flows at a macro level,

For example you as a committee can decide to discuss issues such as viability of Capital Punishment and whether individuals should be given the capacity to take their own life if you wish to,

Or you could take the discussion to a bigger theatre and discuss whether one of capitalism or socialism is the best way to organise and distribute resources in a state.

With that being said this committee would require a fair deal of analysis and critical thinking on your part,

Do contact us if you have any doubt regarding the committee or the conference in general,

The purpose of this document is not to provide you with information and research but to point you towards it,

Do make sure you visit the hyperlinks attached and Google the words and phrases marked as important.

Live long and prosper.

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Difference between a State and a Government

The words Government and State are often used interchangeably, but the fact is that within the purview of this committee and in general, these terms are very different.

State

The term state really has no fixed definition, but the general view of political philosophers points to a space which is fairly clear,

For Example:

According to Gamer, "The state is a community of persons, more or less numerous, permanently occupying a definite portion of territory, independent (or nearly so) of external control and possessing an organised government to which the great body of inhabitants render habitual obedience."

Burgess defined state as a "particular portion of mankind viewed as an organised unit." Harold Laski defined state as "a territorial society divided into government and subjects claiming within its allotted physical area, a supremacy over all other institutions" Oppenheim said, "The state exists when a people is settled in a-country under its own sovereign government."

In terms of Polity the Government in fact is a part of the whole concept of State.

Further Reading:

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/State_(polity)#Theories_of_state_function

http://www.preservearticles.com/2011100414554/what-is-the-meaning-and-definition-of-state.html

http://www.preservearticles.com/201012241588/what-is-the-difference-between-state-and-government.html

Way of Argumentation

In a committee that will solely function on philosophy and view points, it is indeed extremely necessary to establish a simple fact: *What you argue is as important as how you argue it.*

In logic and philosophy, an argument is a series of statements typically used to persuade someone of something and to present reasons for accepting a conclusion.
Therefore, learning the structure of a philosophical argument is a tool that will come in handy in the committee for all delegates.

Keeping that in mind let us become familiar with the two broad types of arguments that there are:

First is **an argument with premise**.

Let us suppose that you wish to convince the committee that apple is a fruit. Here is how to go about it;
the premise is an assumption that something is true. In logic, an argument requires a set of declarative sentences or propositions known as the premises, along with another declarative sentence known as the conclusion.
A very simple example would be that a delegate states his premise-
All fruits grow on trees.

The next stage of the argument is *the substance*, wherein you prove solid facts and substance for your statement and proceed slightly towards the conclusion, the substance is the ultimate proof that will support your proposition.

Progressing with our previous example, the substance here can be- Apple grows on trees.

Now, the last stage is *the conclusion*. The conclusion will be the statement or belief that you have been trying to establish through your argument. Example- Since all fruits grow on trees and apple does too; hence, apple is a fruit.

The second type is **an argument without a premise**.

These arguments usually work when you're trying to propose a move, not a cement fact. Therefore, in a debate where you're saying that all apples should be coloured pink, you answer '**why**', '**how**' and '**so**'; not forming the premise and stating that it is not in your interest whether apple is a fruit or an instrument, just colour it pink.

The different approaches without premise are,

First can be the *basic questioning approach*, where in while arguing three basic questions must be answered- 'why', 'how' and 'so'.

Sometimes you can argue from a commentary perspective. Example, X being the subject matter of debate, delegate feels X needs to be done.
- Why X needs to be done
- How X will be done
- What will be the repercussions when X is done

Another approach is *an economic argument*, which is divided into three parts- need, move and outcome, which is similar to the first approach.

Now let us take this to a practical level like how it would take place in the committee.

Assume a representative brings out the argument that ‘capitalism is impractical because capitalists accumulate majority of the wealth and leave the common people poor.’
This is a basic argument.

There can be questions and rebuttals regarding your statement, ‘what if capitalists accrue wealth through capitalism but distribute it within people, would capitalism still be impractical?’

However, you must keep in mind that *if you accept/reject or agree/disagree with something, it must be on a principle level*. Not a consequential level.

So for this to happen you would need to extract the principle that you either propose or oppose with a particular matter of discussion.

We as the executive board would urge you to build your arguments in a way that ticks all of these required boxes.

Possible Stances you can take

Now to discuss the most essential part of this document,

What are the possible sides you as a member of this committee can take?

As mentioned earlier the committee can choose to discuss either the Micro level topics – Mainly Capital Punishment and Suicide or the Macro level topics which would essentially boil down to what the layman would like to call Capitalism vs Socialism.

We would prefer it if the committee could discuss both.

Addressing the Macro Level debate first,

The representatives can take one of the two mainstream Stances which would either be **PRO CAPITALISM** or **PRO SOCIALISM**.

Pro Capitalism

Capitalism in the most basic sense is an economic system which proposes that the means of production should be owned by individuals.

To read and understand further about capitalism visit-

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Capitalism

http://capitalism.org/

To form basic arguments the Pro Capitalist representatives in the council would have to **defend the core beliefs of capitalism** and would have to **answer the main criticisms** of the same.

Delving deeper into the political roots of the whole concept of Capitalism we understand that Capitalism usually manifests itself within States that are Liberal and Believe in the concept of Liberty.

For this we must understand the basis of Liberal Philosophy

Understanding Liberalism

At that point in history when the Western countries were grappling with the issues of the feudal system and authoritative governments, Liberalism arose in the 17th and 18th centuries as the response to monarchical absolutism. European Liberalists argued that by and large it is best to leave civil society to run itself, in religion, thought, culture and most importantly economic affairs.

The Liberal slogan of "the world goes by itself" summarizes the liberal philosophy.

Before we progress into the different approaches of this thought, what must be maintained is that all approaches were founded on the most basic of ideas of liberty of a liberal individual.
The most authentic form of Liberalism has been concerned with two things; first, the expansion of free functioning of a civil society and second, the restrictions on state activity.

Divergent streams of thought

As we advance deeper into liberalism, one comes across a point where they are met with conflicting views. Here is where the two different streams of thoughts root out.
Individualism and Utilitarianism.

To understand these two approaches, let us look at it from an example point of view. There is a trolley going down a track and there is no way to stop it. If you let it go down the track, it'll run down and kill five people. However, there is a switch in front of you, if you flip the switch it'll divert and kill just one person. What will you do?

In most cases people opt for the second option, that is flip the switch for greater good. This is the basis of Utilitarianism, "the greatest happiness of the greatest number" which is potentially saying that interest of a few can be sacrificed in the interest of more. In simple terms, it is the belief that something has value when it is useful or promotes happiness.

In political sense, utilitarianism generally supports representative democracy, asserting that it is the best means by which government could promote the interests of citizens.

Taking their cue from the notion of a market economy, the utilitarians called for a political system that would guarantee its citizens- the maximum degree of individual freedom of choice and action; which would be accountable to the government.

Practically speaking, problems occur because it is nearly impossible to objectively measure the benefit of an action on an individual level. However, in a broad sense, most government policies that aim for the betterment of a large group of people, if not the overall population are liberal economic policies.

Reverting back to the trolley problem, when a person argues that they would let the trolley take its natural course and not flip the switch because rights of that one individual too must be kept in mind; stems into the other stream of thought- Individualism.

The very basis of the theory is that individual is a rational creature. Also, individual dignity, independent existence and judgement must be given recognition while making public policies.
The theory argues that individual shouldn't suffer in order to benefit a larger part of society.

The belief that your independence, who you are, and your viewpoints should represent you, instead of your culture, family, government.

True individualism, whose pioneers included John Locke, David Hume and Adam Smith maintained that the "spontaneous collaboration of free men often creates things which are greater than their individual minds can ever fully comprehend."

Economic foundations

In France a group of thinkers argued that the best way to cultivate wealth is to allow uncontrolled economic competition. Their advice to government was "*laissez faire, laissez passer*" which meant "let it be, leave it alone".
This laissez-faire doctrine found it's most thorough and influential explanation in *The Wealth of Nations* by Adam Smith.

Smith explains that free trade benefits all parties because competition leads to the production of more and better goods at lower prices.
Leaving individuals free to pursue their self-interest in an exchange economy, based upon a division of labour will benefit the entire group.
The self-seeking individual becomes harnessed to the public good because in exchange money he must serve others in order to serve himself.

But it is only in a genuinely free market that this positive consequence is possible; any other arrangement would lead to exploitation and economic stagnation.

Pro Socialism

What do Scandinavia, Bernie Sanders and Soviet Union have in common?
Socialism - the radical idea of sharing.

Which often makes people wonder- how can the same system be behind the Nazi party and Finland's educational system? This can be explained very simply, socialism is a broad umbrella which shelters very many types of itself.

Note that Communism is not Socialism.
To communists, such as Karl Marx himself, Socialism is only a phase between capitalism and communism. This brings us to an important saying “All communists are socialists but not all socialists are communists.”

Before we move onto the types, we must understand what socialism in its essence really is. *It is when a population collectively owns as well as controls the mean of production and distributes the end result proportionally.*

In practice however, the control is usually delegated to the state while the distribution comes in the form of underlying social welfare to satisfy everyone’s basic needs; such as housing, education and health care.
The end all purpose is to level the playing field for all members of the society, thereby removing class distinctions based on ownership.

For example, USA’s capitalistic society has an expensive higher education, those who can pay are given good quality education and those who can’t are force to compete at a material disadvantage. This leads to class inequality on the basis of generational wealth.

It is important to know that in our globe today, there are no 100% socialistic countries. In that sense socialism is very idealistic. However, there exist different socio-economic systems with socialistic undertones.

TYPES OF SOCIALISM

Now, we must understand that socialism is *huge*; in every sense of the word. It can range from Stalinism to Anarchism, from Liberal socialism to Marxist socialism.

We will discuss the two major types.

First, **Social democracy**, as practiced by Sweden.
It's a subpart of an approach that seeks to promote the ideals of socialism within the context of a democratic system.
It supports economic and social interventions to promote social justice within the framework of a capitalist economy.

Social democracy originated as a political ideology that supported a peaceful transition from capitalism to socialism, using established political processes; in contrast to the revolutionary approach to transition associated with Orthodox Marxism.

This form of democracy usually prioritises improving quality of life through:
- Equal rights and opportunities
- State run welfare system
- Capitalist economy

On the other hand the **Marxism-Leninism**, which was practiced in Soviet Union, China and Cuba, it prioritises
- The dictatorship of the proletariat
- State-dominance over the economy
- Opposition to bourgeoisie democracy and opposition to capitalism

Marxism–Leninism first became a distinct philosophical movement in the Soviet Union. However, one must not confuse it with Communism, as it rejected the notions of world revolution as a prerequisite for building socialism and of a gradual transition from capitalism to socialism. Both ideas are quite central to communism.

The goal of Marxism–Leninism is the development of a state into a socialist republic through the leadership of a revolutionary vanguard.

Both the types- Social Democracy and Marxism-Leninism strive for similar utopian goals, they just have different approaches.
Socialism along with its logical extreme- Communism, may be backed by rational theory but it also requires rational practice to go along with it.
Case in point is that social democracies such as Denmark, Norway and Switzerland are the happiest in the world. However, other socialist countries like China and Cuba suffer from terrible human rights abuse like moderate slavery and censorship.

WHO IS A SOCIALIST?

We've arrived at the understanding that there is no way to sum up all the types of Socialism under one category. So, how does one term anything as Socialism and most importantly- who is a socialist.

Luckily for us, Michael Freedman in his book *Ideology and Political Theory* has laid down five attributes of a socialist:

I. *Society is more than the individual*
   this contradicts some of the very roots of United States' in terms of individual liberalism; which says that the individual is at the core of everything and that they lend themselves to the society, not the other way around. Which helps us arrive at the conclusion that Socialism is the opposite of Liberalism; often mistaken as the antonym of capitalism.
II. *Human Welfare is a societal objective*
   that could be an objective of education, health care, education. Either way that you cut it, a socialist would believe that there is a societal responsibility to at least address it as an objective for human welfare.

III. *All humans are productive*

the main quote of socialism is “To each according to his ability, to each according to his need.” Meaning that all humans are productive and if we all do something for the society, we all will be able to take back something at the end of the day.

IV. *All humans are equal*

In this case a pure socialist is going to believe that capitalism doesn’t not inherently create equality and freedom. Socialist is a concrete idea of freedom and equality, meaning that it has to be real and pragmatic and felt instead of being just an idea like in the Jefferson’s declaration. A socialist would say that how is anyone equal if born in dire poverty without opportunity; you might be free in a theoretic sense but you are no free everyday when you wake up hungry.

V. *History is a wave of progressivism*

Meaning that it makes life better for everyone

Again the same method should be applied by Pro-Socialist representatives, **defend core beliefs** and **refute main criticisms**.

Besides the two stances highlighted above representatives can also take another radical stance by opposing the State Structure as a whole, also known as **Anarchism.**

Anarchism

Anarchism stands for a mode of thought which holds that society can and should be organized without the coercive authority of the state.

William Godwin was one of the most active proponents of a stateless society.

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Anarchism

http://www.seesharppress.com/anarchismwhatis.html

Research Tips

Representatives are requested to choose a stance which they deem fit and understand in depth, all that the chosen theory/stance believes in.

Not only are representatives urged to read in depth about their own streams of thought, we request that you also understand fully what the other ideologies believe in, understand their core values, read upon their criticisms and form your arguments around them,

Not only would it make the debate within the committee more engaging it would also make your arguments more sound as you would be able to weigh your ideologies against theirs.

Second guide with Micro level debates to follow.

For Further Reading

http://www.diffen.com/difference/Capitalism_vs_Socialism

http://www.forbes.com/sites/cedricmuhammad/2013/11/20/3-reasons-why-good-socialism-defeats-bad-capitalism/

http://townhall.com/columnists/johnhawkins/2012/03/20/5_reasons_socialism_is_inferior_to_capitalism/page/full

Use these links to guide your research and not as your research, pick up key words and theories and read further into those and then form your arguments around them.